Isolated islands

When Charles Darwin studied finch populations in the remote Galapagos Islands, he noticed that the **island** finches had different shaped beaks to the **mainland** finches from which they were descended. The mainland finches' beaks were suited to eating grain, which was scarce on the islands. The island finches' beaks were better suited to eating insects, fruit or leaves. Darwin believed that over many generations, island finches with diverse beak shapes survived better than those whose beaks were the same as the mainland finches.

Darwin proposed that the finches that had adapted so they could eat a variety of foods, rather than depending on the limited supplies of grain, survived and passed on their characteristics to their young. Because the finches were isolated, the genetic base was small and the beak characteristics of the mainland finches were bred out over time. Darwin described the survival of those species that changed their characteristics in order to survive as **natural selection**.

☞ **1** Scarce means **a)** plentiful **b)** scared **c)** very few **d)** damaged.

2 Add the missing vowels (a, e, i, o, u) to complete the table below.

	Beak shape	**Food type**
	r__ __nd__d b__ __k	b__ds __nd fr__ __t
	sh__rp __nd n__rr__w	__ns__cts
	sh__rp tr__ __ng__l__r	l__ __v__s

3 Some of these statements are correct, but some are untrue. Rewrite the false statements so they are true.

a) Animals' characteristics change over time.

_____

b) Isolated finches only eat grain.

_____

c) Charles Darwin studied finches in Australia.

_____

d) Isolated populations adapt to their environment.

_____

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